

Session 13: The Ark as a Symbolic Eden and Tabernacle

Key Takeaways

- The word *tebah*, translated as “ark,” is an Egyptian loanword that means sacred shrine, sarcophagus, or box.
- The ark is a symbolic Eden temple. Its design matches the three-tiered structure of sacred spaces: the garden in Eden, the tabernacle, and the temple.

The Design of Noah’s Ark

“While popular depictions of the ark often mislead one into viewing it as a boat, the vessel, having no sails, rudder, oarsman, etc., was no boat, and Noah was no 'captain' steering his own fate. Indeed, that the ark was completely given over to the sovereign guidance of God seems to be a primary emphasis of the narrative ... [T]he instructions to build the ark in Gen 6:13-17 utilize three times as many verses than for the flood itself, demonstrating ... the emphasis on the ark itself as the means of deliverance. How would ancient readers have understood the ark? Several considerations lead to the conclusion that the ark was meant to be seen as symbolizing a temple.”

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 146-147.

The Word Ark (*Tebah*)

The Hebrew word for Noah’s ark is “*tebah*” (Heb. תבה), and in the Hebrew Bible it appears only in the Genesis flood story and the story of Moses’ deliverance through an ark (*tebah* is usually translated as “basket”).

The rare word *tebah* is actually an Egyptian loanword (*dbt*) into Hebrew, which means “sacred shrine, sarcophagus, box.”

For more information on this word, see Kohler and Baumgartner’s book *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament* (1,678) and Yoshiyuki Muchiki’s book *Egyptian Proper Names and Loanwords in North-West Semitic* (59).

The sense of “sacred shrine” is significant for the ark’s cultural and symbolic meaning in this story.

"Whereas [the word 'tebah'] is applied to a ship in the flood story (Gen. 6:14), it is being used in its real meaning of 'chest, holy shrine, coffin.' Such a chest generally had the form of a divine shrine, and served as housing for images of gods which were dedicated to temples. Of the numerous shrines which have been preserved several are in stone of different qualities, while others are in plain wood ... The simpler ones ... [had] the form of a longish chest with a small door in the upper portion of the front for statues of gods about the size of a child. Such chests or arks were to be found in all the Egyptian temples from the earliest to the latest times, and they were duly noted by the Greek writers ... On certain festivals as well as on the occasion of great victory fetes they were borne in solemn procession, or were carried on the Nile, from one temple-town to another, on a bier which was usually given the form of a bark, such as was conceived as vehicle for the sun god Re, Osiris, and other gods."

Yahudah, Abraham S. (2003). [*Language of the Pentateuch in its Relation to Egyptian*](#). Kessinger Publishing. 205.

"The word ... 'ark' occurs in only two sections of Scripture: here (Gen. 6:14-15) and in the section that describes the birth and rescue of Moses (Exod. 2:3-5). This is certainly no coincidence. By the verbal parallel, the Torah wished, apparently, to draw attention to the parallelism of theme. In both cases there is to be saved from drowning one who is worthy of salvation and is destined to bring deliverance to others; here it is humanity that is to be saved, there it is the chosen people; here it is the macrocosm that has to be preserved, there it is the microcosm."

Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [*A Commentary on the Book of Genesis: From Noah to Abraham*](#). Varda Books. 59.

The Materials of the Ark

The materials of the ark listed in 6:14 contain a puzzle that is elegantly solved by adopting the translation "reeds" (Heb. *qanim*) instead of "nests/rooms" (Heb. *qinniym*). The most compelling case for this reading has been made by John Day in the chapter titled "Rooms or Reeds in Noah's Ark (Genesis 6:14)?" in his book *From Creation to Babel: Studies in Genesis 1-11* (Day, 2014).

Genesis 6:14 Instructor's Translation

Make for yourself an ark of gopher (גפר) trees
you will make the ark (a) "with nests" OR (b) "of reeds,"
and you will pitch (כפר) it inside and out with pitch (כפר).

The Masoretic Text contains the consonant *q-n-y-m* with the vowel points *qinniym* (קִנִּיִּים) so that the word means "nests." This is the standard Hebrew word for a bird's nest, although it can sometimes be used metaphorically for a human dwelling located high in the hills for security like a nest.

Bird's Nest

Deuteronomy 22:6 NASB

"If you happen to come upon a **bird's nest** along the way, in any tree or on the ground, with young ones or eggs ...

Psalms 84:3 NASB

The bird also has found a house,
and the swallow a **nest** for herself, where she may lay her young,
even your altars, O LORD of hosts,
my King and my God.

See also Deut. 32:11; Job 39:27; Prov. 27:8; Isa. 10:14, 16:12

Human Dwelling Portrayed as a Bird's Nest

Numbers 24:21 NASB*

And he looked at the Cananite (קניזי), and took up his discourse and said,
"Your dwelling place is enduring,
And your **nest** (קן) is set in the cliff.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Obadiah 1:4 NASB

"Though you build high like the eagle,
Though you set your **nest** among the stars,
From there I will bring you down," declares the LORD.

See also Jer. 49:16; Hab. 2:9

While a human dwelling can be likened to a bird's nest, it's clear that the word refers metaphorically to an entire dwelling and that the bird's nest image is part of why the word was chosen. The word does not refer to the particular room of a dwelling in any of the examples in the Hebrew Bible. Therefore, the translation "rooms" is not supported by any contextual evidence. And yet it is the translation adopted by most modern English translations.

There is an overwhelming amount of evidence that the word means "reeds" and was originally vocalized with different vowels, *qaniym* (קניִים), which means "reeds" and is an active word in biblical Hebrew (1 Kgs. 14:15; 2 Kgs. 18:21; Isa. 19:6).

This interpretation is likely for a number of reasons.

- Genesis 6:14 is a three-part description of the materials of the ark. The dimensions and internal design of the ark is briefly described only in 6:15-16. The mention of "rooms" here is out of place.
- Genesis 6:14-16 contains instructions on the topics of materials, dimensions, and design in sequence, and each topic is described in three lines. This makes it likely that the word "*qnym*" is referring to materials.

Pattern	Verse
Materials 1 2 3	14 Make for yourself an ark of gopher (גפר) trees; you will make the ark of reeds, and you will pitch (כפר) it inside and out with pitch (כפר).
Dimensions 1 2 3	15 This is how you will make it: 300 cubits, the length of the ark 50 cubits, its width 30 cubits, its height.
Design 1 2 3	16 You will make a window for the ark, and you will finish it to a cubit from the top; and you will set the door of the ark in its side; with lowers, seconds, and thirds you will make it
Three-Part Descriptions of Material, Dimensions, and Design of the Ark. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

- Genesis 6:14 contains two other Akkadian loanwords, the verb and nouns for “pitch” (*kpr*), instead of the more common Hebrew words for pitch (*khemar*, Gen. 11:3) or “tar” (*zaphet*, Exod. 2:3). It cannot be a coincidence, then, that *qanim* is also an Akkadian word for “reed.”
- In the parallel Mesopotamian flood stories, the arks are made of reed using the Akkadian word “*qa-ne*” (Atrahasis 3.2.11-14). In fact, in these parallel stories, the flood hero uses the reed walls of his hut as the shell of the ark.
- In the design pattern parallel to Noah’s ark, the only other ark (*tebah*) in the Hebrew Bible is Moses’ ark, which his mother makes out of “reeds” (Heb. *gome’* / גומא) (Exod. 2:3). The gopher wood mentioned is therefore the frame of the structure, while the reeds form the actual hull, and the pitch is the caulking.

The Ark as a Symbolic Eden and Tabernacle

The ark is set on analogy with Eden. It is the divinely initiated place of refuge from chaos where humanity lives together in peace with the animals.

The tabernacle is a symbolic micro-Eden and is set on analogy to the ark.

“Both ark and tabernacle are commanded by God, whose precise directions are communicated to the human leader, who proceeds to carry out the directions in obedient detail. Both Noah and Moses found favor in God’s sight (33:12-17; Gen. 6:8). At the end of the building of each (39:42-43; Gen. 6:22) it is said that they did just as God had commanded. The same Hebrew word is used for the ark and for the basket in which Moses, like Noah, was set afloat on the chaotic waters (see at 2:1-10). It has even been suggested that the ark of Noah is a temple structure, similar in construction to those found in Mesopotamia. This is in tune with Christian symbolism of the ark through the ages, which commonly sees it in terms of a church afloat amid the waters of chaos. Floodwaters and wilderness are the two most prominent symbols for chaos in the Old Testament. Both ‘sanctuaries’ are portable, one on sea, one on land; they are used to carry the people through the waters / sands of chaos. Both are viewed as a means by which the people of God can move in a secure and ordered way through a world of disorder on their way to the new creation. It is on the first day of the new year that the floodwaters abate and the covering of the ark is taken off (Gen. 8:13), the same day that the tabernacle is set up and dedicated (Gen. 40:2). One is thereby invited to see the building of the tabernacle in chapters 35-40 in terms of re-creation, God’s beginning again with world / Israel on the far side of apostasy.”

Fretheim, Terence (2010). [*Exodus: Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 268-269.

“The dimensions of the ark—length, breadth, height—are given according to the standard construction formula found elsewhere in [Exodus 25:10, 17, 23](#) ... At 18 inches or 45 centimeters to the cubit (for precise equivalents, see Roland de Vaux, *Ancient Israel*, 197), the ark was a huge box about 450 ft (135 m) long, 75 ft (22 m) wide, and 45 ft (13 m) high ... The surface area of the ark was thus exactly three times as much as that of the tabernacle courtyard, 100 × 50 cubits (Exod 27:9-13) ... In Exodus 25-31, there are also parallels in phraseology with the directions for building the tabernacle and its furniture that suggest that both ark and tabernacle were seen as a sanctuary for the righteous.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15](#). Thomas Nelson. 172-173.

The vocabulary of the ark instructions and the instructions for the ark of the covenant are remarkably similar and are the only two divinely commanded structures in the Torah.

The Ark of Noah

Genesis 6:14-15 NASB*

¹⁴ Make for yourself an ark (תבה) of wood of gopher (גפר) ... and you will pitch (copher / כפר) it with pitch (copher / כפר), inside and outside (מבית ומחוץ) ... ¹⁵ 300 cubits its length (ארכו), 50 cubits its width (רחבו), and 30 cubits its height (קמתו)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:21 Instructor's Translation

And take for yourself food which will be eaten and gather it ... it will be for you and for them for food (והיה ... לאכזה).

The Ark of the Covenant

Exodus 25:10-11, 17 NIV*

¹⁰ Make an ark (אֲרוֹן) of wood of acacia, two and a half cubits its length (אֲרֵכּוֹ), a cubit and a half its width (רָחְבּוֹ), and a cubit and a half its height (קִמְתּוֹ), ¹¹ and you will overlay it with pure gold, inside and outside (מִבֵּית וּמִחוּץ) ... ¹⁷ Make an atonement cover (capporet / כַּפֶּרֶת) of pure gold, two and a half cubits its length (אֲרֵכּוֹ), and a cubit and a half its width (רָחְבּוֹ).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 16:15, 33-34 Instructor's Translation

¹⁵ Moses said, "This is the bread which Yahweh gave to you for food (לֶאֱכֹלָה) ... ³³ Take a jar and place in it a full omer of manna, and rest (נָוִיחַ) it before Yahweh ..." ³⁴ So he rested it (נָוִיחַ) before the testimony ...

"While it is possible that the 'pitch' (כפר) might alert a well-educated ancient reader to an Akkadian loan-word, it might equally evoke the rich cultic overtones of 'ransom' (כפר), 'the atonement cover' (כפרת), and the verb 'to atone' (כפר) that is associated with so many priestly rituals. The *tebah* becomes the place of mercy and ransom when the waters cover over and atone for the violence of the world."

Harper, Elizabeth A. (2021). "You Shall Make a Tebah." Academia.edu.

Noah's Ark as an Idealized Temple

In the ancient Mesopotamian flood account of Gilgamesh, the description of the ark fits precisely with the iconic shape of an ancient ziggurat, a temple that symbolized the cosmic mountain.

"The ark of Utnapishtim was intended to symbolically represent a ziggurat ... that is to say, it is the architectural embodiment of the cosmic mountain ... the curious design of this ark, far from being the random escapade of creative imagination, depicted a symbol that was fluent and integral to the religious language of ancient Mesopotamia."

Holloway, Steven W. (1991). "What Ship Goes There: The Flood Narratives in the Gilgamesh Epic and Genesis Considered in Light of Ancient Near Eastern Temple Ideology." *Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft*, Volume 103. 339.

- The equal length, width, and height makes us think of a giant cube, but notice the later detail of "six decks" and "seven divisions." This describes the form of a ziggurat, whose height equaled its square width and then had six steps, each with a deck and seven divisions with a smaller top.
- He offers a sacrificial offering atop the mountain where the ark has landed.

When one compares the very brief descriptions of the ark in Genesis 6:14-16 with the longer, but also brief, descriptions of Solomon's temple in Jerusalem, a number of features leap off the page.

The dimensions are listed in the same order.

Genesis 6:15 Instructor's Translation

This is how you will make it:
300 cubits, the length of the ark

50 cubits, its width
30 cubits, its height.

1 Kings 6:2 Instructor's Translation

And the house that king Solomon built for Yahweh
60 cubits, its length
20 cubits, its width
30 cubits, its height.

The arrangement of the measurements is the same, but they only share the same height (30 cubits). However, if one takes the additional measurements given in 1 Kings 6:5-6 that account for the “side chambers” and the “stories” that terraced down to the courtyard, the entire structure would be around 100 cubits long and 50 cubits wide. For more information, see Cory Crawford’s “Noah’s Architecture” (6-7) and Steven Holloway’s “What Ship Goes There?” (202).

Both accounts, which are spare in detail, draw attention to the door (פתח).

Genesis 6:16 NASB*

and you will set the **door** (פתח) of the ark in its **side** (צדה)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Kings 6:8 NASB*

The **door** (פתח) of the lower **side** (צלע) was on the right side of the temple ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“In 1 Kings 6:8 the entrance to the three-decker structure is specifically noted as being on the right side of the house, just as Gen. 6:16 famously places the door of the three decker ark in its side. The note in Genesis has perhaps most blatantly raised exegetical questions about the seaworthiness of Noah’s vessel ... In these texts, both of which are spare in detail relative to other building accounts, it is striking that the side door should be clearly indicated in close conjunction with similar terminology.”

Crawford, C.D. (2013). “Noah’s Architecture: The Role of Sacred Space in Ancient Near Eastern Flood Myths.” *Constructions of Space IV: Further Developments in Examining Ancient Israel’s Social Space*. Bloomsbury T & T Clark. 7.

Both structures are three-tiered, which was a common architectural feature used in ancient Near Eastern temples to symbolize the three-tiered cosmos (heavens, land, waters).

Genesis 6:16 Instructor's Translation

You will make it with **lower [floors]** (תחתים), **second** (שנים), and **third** (שלשים).

1 Kings 6:5-6 Instructor's Translation

And he made side chambers all around the **lower** (תחתים) ... and the **middle** (שנים) ... and the **third** (שלשים).

“The ark functions as a substitute cosmos and refuge from the destruction of the ordered world. And once this mini-world is made, such that it is suitable for inhabitants, it is filled up with living creatures: wildlife, herd-animals, creepers, birds, humans, so that it is a creation in miniature ... Noah’s three-decked ark, symbolizing a temple, constitutes a microcosm of ‘the heavens and the earth,’ with living creatures to boot.”

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 152.

“In their basic design both Noah’s ark and Solomon’s temple reflect the three-decker world of ancient Near Eastern cosmogonies, a feature which, for fairly obvious reasons, could not be reproduced in the wilderness sanctuary. In light of the ziggurat symbolism in the Mesopotamian flood narrative, it is unlikely that chance could account for the correspondence in dimensional proportions and structure between Noah’s ark and the Solomonic temple.”

Holloway, Steven W. (1991). “What Ship Goes There: The Flood Narratives in the Gilgamesh Epic and Genesis Considered in Light of Ancient Near Eastern Temple Ideology.” *Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft*, Volume 103. 339.

Both structures are completed with the same vocabulary.

Genesis 6:16 NASB*

and to the cubit **you shall complete it** (כלה) from above

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Kings 6:9 NASB*

And he built the house and **he completed it** (כלה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Explaining the literary appearance of the flood vessels as products of cultural notions of sacred space best accounts for the striking differences between the flood vessels in each tradition. It allows the use of a similar conceptual framework—the congruence of flood vessel and monumental sacred architecture—to be applied to different cultural forms, for Israel, its temple, and for Babylon, the ziqqurat. This observation allows us to reject the pejorative analyses of Mesopotamian ark construction discussed above, which saw little value in the “unrealistic” use of “fanciful” proportions and championed the biblical dimensions as more realistic than those in Gilgamesh. If the affiliation of ark and temple is correct, the Mesopotamian and biblical texts exemplify equivalent phenomena: the different dimensions given in each are the result of different architectural realities, rather than some other aesthetic or nautical rationale.”

Crawford, C.D. (2013). “Noah’s Architecture: The Role of Sacred Space in Ancient Near Eastern Flood Myths.” *Constructions of Space IV: Further Developments in Examining Ancient Israel’s Social Space*. Bloomsbury T & T Clark. 11.

Ark as Temple as Yahweh's Presence

The ark as temple as Yahweh’s presence connection was picked up and developed by later biblical authors in very creative ways.

Psalm 32:6-7 NASB

⁶ Therefore, let everyone who is godly pray to you in a time when you may be found; surely in a flood of great waters, they will not reach him.

⁷ You are my hiding place; you preserve me from trouble; you surround me with songs of deliverance. Selah.

Psalm 29:9-10 NASB*

⁹ ... in Yahweh's temple everything says, "Glory!"

¹⁰ Yahweh sat enthroned at the flood; yes, Yahweh sits as King forever.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 46:1-5 NASB

¹ God is our refuge and strength,
a very present help in trouble.

² Therefore we will not fear,
though the earth should change
and though the mountains slip into the heart of the sea;

³ though its waters roar and foam,
though the mountains quake at its swelling pride. Selah.

⁴ There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God,
the holy dwelling places of the Most High.

⁵ God is in the midst of her, she will not be moved;
God will help her when morning dawns.

Isaiah 8:7-8 NASB

⁷ Now therefore, behold, the Lord is about to bring on them the strong and abundant waters of the Euphrates,
even the king of Assyria and all his glory;
and it will rise up over all its channels and go over all its banks.

⁸ Then it will sweep on into Judah, it will overflow and pass through,
it will reach even to the neck;
and the spread of its wings will fill the breadth of your land, O Immanuel.

Isaiah 8:13-14 NASB

¹³ It is the LORD of hosts whom you should regard as holy.
And he shall be your fear,
and he shall be your dread.

¹⁴ Then he shall become a sanctuary;
but to both the houses of Israel, a stone to strike and a rock to stumble over,
and a snare and a trap for the inhabitants of Jerusalem.

"[The] ark was designed to be a replica of the cosmos conceptualized as a three-storied house of God, the temple residence of God (Isa. 66:1). Besides the three-stories structure, the door and window are mentioned as architectural features of the ark, and these too have counterparts in the cosmic creation house with its window of heaven (see [Gen. 7:11](#); [8:2](#)) and the door of the deep (see [Job 38:8-11](#)), both access points for the flood waters. As in the case of other replicas of the heavenly sanctuary, like the tabernacle and temple as well as the visible cosmos, so in the case of this ark-house, it was God who provided the architectural plans (Gen. 6:14-16) ... Accordingly, the ark, with its prototypically glorified occupants, was a typological symbol of the consummate cosmic holy city as well as the cosmic heavenly temple."

Kline, Meredith (2006). [*God, Heaven, and Har Magedon: A Covenantal Tale of Cosmos and Telos*](#). Wipf and Stock. 87-89.

Reflection Question

In what way does the design of the ark reflect the description of the garden in Eden? How does the design reflect descriptions of the tabernacle and the temple?